



Unfinished business: Shafali has now set her sights on the upcoming T20 World Cup, determined to exorcise the demons of India's defeat to Australia in the 2020 edition.

For Shafali, who once had to cut her hair short and look like a boy, to be able to even play the sport, the importance of winning a second World Cup in quick succession is crystal clear. "I went back to Rohtak two weeks after the World Cup win, after meeting the Prime Minister and attending other events. I got the chance to be part of TV shows I grew up watching, like *Kaun Banega Crorepati* and *The Kapil Sharma Show*. The whole city turned up for me. People I'd never met before came to welcome me. Men's cricket has always had far more support here, so to see people come out made that day very special.

"To get recognition from the place

you come from is something else. My family insulated me from many detractors who didn't understand why my parents let their daughter play cricket. There were boys I played with who used to say nothing would come of it. They would say, '*Kuch nahin rakha women's cricket mein.*' I stopped playing with them after I was selected for my state and began playing international cricket very early. Now, a bunch of them come up to me and say, 'See, remember I trained you before. See what you're doing now.' It's quite funny."

What she couldn't do in 2020, she achieved in 2025. The captain of India's maiden U19 Women's T20 World Cup winning side took matters into her own hands for the senior team, outside circumstances notwithstanding, to make history. The true Gen Z kid she is, Shafali's appetite remains far from satiated. If 2025 is anything to go by, it's going to be quite a ride!

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If you could mute someone on the WhatsApp groups and chats you are a part of, who would it be?

Renuka (Singh). Most times, when she sees or reads something, she will promptly send it to me and discuss it. I do need moments of peace sometimes, so it will be her! (Laughs)

What is your go-to excuse to miss training?

Honestly, to this day, I've never felt like missing training. This is the stuff that's close to our hearts, so why would we want to miss it?

If you can swap a skill with any of your teammates, what would it be, and what's the skill?

That would be with Pooja Vastrakar and her fitness. If I could get a little of that, I'd be in a really good space. As for core skills, I am very happy with the ones I have. God has given me a lot, touchwood! Fitness is what I want from Pooja.

One bowler who gives you nightmares?

Brunt [Katherine Sciver-Brunt]... I had a lot of fun with her because her variations were incredible. No two balls in the over would be the same. Her natural aggression is so interesting to take on as an opponent, so I enjoyed batting against her. She used to say a lot of stuff to me, but I didn't know how to give it back. I often think, I wish she was still playing — I could respond better then.

What is the most expensive thing you own?

A Volvo XC90. I got it two years ago. I recently bought a two-seater MG.

If you can add one rule in cricket, what would it be?

A batter should be able to bat twice.

If someone makes a movie about your life, who should play you?

Aamir Khan can play my father's role well. I'd like the actor who played Geeta in *Dangal* (Fatima Sana Shaikh) to play me.